string theory have to say about the spacetime singularity at the center of a black hole? This is a topic of intense current research, but as with the question of information loss, it has not yet been settled. String theory deftly deals with a variety of other singularities—the rips and tears in space discussed in Chapter 11 and in the first part of this chapter.15 But if you have seen one singularity you have not seen them all. The fabric of our universe can be ripped, punctured, and torn in many different ways. String theory has given us profound insights into some of these singularities, but others, the black hole singularity among them, have so far eluded the string theorists' reach. The essential reason for this, once again, is the reliance on perturbative tools in string theory whose approximations, in this case, cloud our ability to analyze reliably and fully what happens at the deep interior point of a black hole.

However, given the recent tremendous progress in nonperturbative methods and their successful application to other aspects of black holes, string theorists have high hopes that it won't be long before the mysteries residing at the center of black holes start to unravel.